

# Hindsight Afterthought

**Prakash Karat was being economical with the truth when he denied a part of the interview he had given to this magazine last week. INDIA TODAY recounts its meeting with Karat and thereafter.**

Issuing clarifications comes quite easily to politicians—Left, right and centre. CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat has issued one regarding the interview given to INDIA TODAY last week which was part of the cover story in the issue dated December 24, 2007. He has denied a part of the interview and accused INDIA TODAY of resorting to “dubious journalism”, of trying to “impair relations between the Left and the UPA”, and of trying to create an “atmosphere of insecurity about the Central government”. He also said that it was “significant” that the interview appeared on the eve of the polling for the Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh Assembly elections.

Karat’s anger is based on what he believes is factual misrepresentation of comments he made during the course of the interview he gave us last week. He now denies having told us that if the UPA Government goes ahead with the Indo-US nuclear agreement, all political parties should be prepared for elections any time.

INDIA TODAY would like to set the record straight. When we sought a meeting with Karat in connection with our annual Newsmaker story we were doing on him, he asked us to send him the questions in advance. Accordingly, we e-mailed him a set of questions. Instead of replying to our questions via e-mail, he chose to invite us over for a meeting, making it clear that he would give answers to the questions mailed to him and if the need arose (after we read the answers that he had typed out on paper), give oral answers to possible follow-up questions.

When we (INDIA TODAY Editor Prabhu Chawla and me along with Photo Editor Bandeep Singh) went to meet Karat at his AKG Bhavan office on December 11 (Tuesday) at 6.30 p.m., the interview, scheduled for less than half-hour, stretched over an hour during which Karat not only answered the questions originally e-mailed to him but several more which came up during our discussions. One such question related to CPI(M)’s possible moves in the event of the UPA Government going ahead with the Indo-US nuclear agreement.

The specific question asked of him was: *And if they proceed (with the deal), are you prepared for elections?*

To which his answer was: *“If this is the issue they want to break up with us on, political parties need to be prepared for elections anytime.”*

There were several other questions, the answers of which were kept off the record on his request.

It is also important to note that Karat was initially hesitant in answering any question related to the political violence in Nandigram and it was after a lot of persuasion that he finally consented to give an oral answer. Other questions to which he gave answers orally included one on his initiation into Marxism. Karat has now conveniently included the Nandigram question and his answer in the so-called “transcript of the interview” published on the CPI(M)

website, purporting it to be his written reply to our question. Karat chose to put on his party’s website what is at best a selective account of what transpired during the meeting.

*Ganashakti*, CPI(M)’s Bengali mouthpiece, has headlined in its December 16, 2007 issue, a front page story on Karat’s “denial” as “Yellow Journalism of INDIA TODAY”. In this article, the newspaper has quoted External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee as saying that Karat told him that he had not made the specific remark which INDIA TODAY had published. The newspaper has accused INDIA TODAY of “fabricating” both the question and the answer. We can only come to the conclusion that Karat tells us something and the external affairs minister something else. It is of course Karat and his party’s prerogative to run with the hare and



**HALF TRUTHS: The great CPI(M) helmsman protests too much**

hunt with the hound.

On December 8, 2007, Karat had told his party’s Delhi unit that although “CPI(M) does not want the BJP to benefit from the fall of the Government (at the Centre) but we don’t want them (the Government) to carry on with IAEA talks beyond December. But if the Government goes ahead with the talks, then it should be prepared for mid-term polls”. It was a closed-door meeting but strangely his party-funded channel Kairali telecast his speech and other TV channels also aired the footage offered to them by Kairali. This in effect was what Karat told INDIA TODAY too. It is unfortunate that he accused INDIA TODAY of “dubious journalism”.

Till date neither Karat nor his office has sent us a rejoinder or clarification. We have never shied from publishing the other side. INDIA TODAY stands by the interview as published in the issue dated December 24, 2007.

**by Satarupa Bhattacharya**